Prologue

We have named our species *Homo sapiens* – the wise human. But it is debatable how well we have lived up to the name.

Over the last 100,000 years, we Sapiens have certainly accumulated enormous power. Just listing all our discoveries, inventions and conquests would fill volumes. But power isn't wisdom, and after 100,000 years of discoveries, inventions and conquests humanity has pushed itself into an existential crisis. We are on the verge of ecological collapse, caused by the misuse of our own power. We are also busy creating new technologies like artificial intelligence (AI) that have the potential to escape our control and enslave or annihilate us. Yet instead of our species uniting to deal with these existential challenges, international tensions are rising, global cooperation is becoming more difficult, countries are stockpiling doomsday weapons and a new world war does not seem impossible.

If we Sapiens are so wise, why are we so self-destructive?

At a deeper level, although we have accumulated so much information about everything from DNA molecules to distant galaxies, it doesn't seem that all this information has given us an answers the big questions of life: who are we? What should we aspire to? What is a good life, and how should we live it? Despite the stupendous amounts of information at our disposal, we are as susceptible as our ancient ancestors to fantasy and delusion. Nazism and Stalinism are but two recent examples of the mass insanity that occasionally engulfs even modern societies. Nobody disputes that humans today have a lot more information and power than in the Stone Age, but it is far from certain that we understand ourselves and our role in the universe much better.

Why are we so good at accumulating more information and power, but far less successful at acquiring wisdom? Throughout history many